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Mrs. Hart

AP Literature

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The Canyon We Never Crossed

For years, hiking had been a special activity between my father and me. We climbed mountains and tracked our stats together: his pack heavy with gear, mine mostly for show. So when he announced the rim-to-rim hike of the Grand Canyon, a twenty-four-mile descent from the North Rim down to the Colorado River and then up again to the South Rim, I was ready. My grandfather signed up for this too, though I never really understood why. At eleven years old, I didn't know much about challenges or dangers; I just followed along. My sister, April, joined as well. She was athletic and confident, though she had just recovered from a case of hand, foot, and mouth disease she had caught after sharing sweaty towels at a softball tournament in South Carolina.

We left the cabin at two in the morning, our flashlights slicing through the surprisingly cold night air of the North Rim. Commencing at an elevation of 8,000 feet, we marched together in silence, collectively experiencing an awkward mix of sleep deprivation and budding adrenaline. My father said the downward descent of the canyon had to be conquered before sunrise, so we could make it past "the box," an inferno of black canyon walls that reached 120 degrees in midday sun. So I kept treading blindly beside him in the darkness, just alongside an endless cliff that we could not see into. My grandfather, who had come all the way from Florida to prove he could still be athletic, despite his decades of inactivity, quickly fell behind us.

Each swallow of water felt thick. My stomach hurt, and chills ran through my arms.

“Dad,” I said, “I don’t feel so good....”

He stopped. “Like tired, or sick?”

I showed him my hands. Red and itchy bumps had formed.

“He’s fine,” April snapped. “We have to keep going!”

To compound matters, we realized my grandfather was not with us. We turned our lights uphill, and the beams barely reached him. Even from far away we could hear his wheezing in the high-altitude oxygen-deprived atmosphere.

“We’re done,” my father pronounced. “We have to turn around.”

April's fury arose. “Because of him?” she hissed, pointing at me. “We can’t stop because of him. He can always deal with it!” Her voice cracked, and tears mumbled her words. My father was already heading back up the trail, but she stood still, glaring at me.

“You ruined everything.”

I had no words. She was never this angry before; in fact, she just doesn’t get angry ever. I knew this trip had been building up for months, and this was the climax, but nevertheless, to this day I do not understand why she was mad at *me*, for catching *her* sickness.

No words were spoken after that. By the time we climbed back up and reached our cabin beds, the moon and stars were still out. The next morning, the whole experience felt like it had been dreamt. I woke to blistered and shockingly itchy feet. I was glad my father had turned us around that night. I don’t know what would have happened if we kept going. But we never made it to the other side of the canyon. My Dad promised we will go back one day. Life is full of unexpected surprises, some good and some not. I embrace them all and look forward to the next adventure.